

Periods and ellipses

A PERIOD ENDS A SENTENCE, WHEREAS AN ELLIPSIS INDICATES THAT A SENTENCE IS UNFINISHED.

A period marks the end of a complete statement. It can also be used to show that a word has been abbreviated. An ellipsis represents text omitted from a sentence.

SEE ALSO

◀ 54–55 Voices and moods

◀ 68–69 Sentences

Exclamation points 112–113 ▶

Capital letters 158–159 ▶

Abbreviations 172–173 ▶



• If an **abbreviation** with a period comes at the end of a sentence, no additional period is needed. For example, “The undersea experiment commenced at 4:00 p.m.”

Ending a statement

A period is used at the end of a statement. There is no space before a period, but a space is left after one. It is followed by a capital letter at the start of the next sentence.

The undersea experiment ended.

This period marks the end of the sentence. 

The undersea experiment ended.
said, “Swim to the surface.”

REAL WORLD

Web and e-mail addresses

The period is used today in website and e-mail addresses. In these situations, it is known as a “dot” and functions as a separator between the parts of the address. Unlike in normal writing, the dot is stated when the address is read aloud, so the example here would read “w-w-w-dot-d-k-dot-com.”



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Commands

Some commands, including orders and polite requests, end with a period. For commands that express greater emotion, such as anger or surprise, an exclamation point should be used.

Swim to the surface.

This period marks the end of this request. 

Get out of the water!

This exclamation point expresses urgency. 